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The San Francisco of Alfred Pioche and Charles Meryon

BY O. J. ROTHROCK

WE could well be mistaken to allow François Louis Alfred Pioche no vision of San Francisco more ideal than that suggested by one of its legend establishments, "El Dorado. The Temple of Chance." True, he was among the first to join the great Gold Rush, and one of the few Forty-Niners actually to become rich. Yet the record of his enterprises demonstrates, that for him the Golden Gate led not to the prospects of the mines beyond (however appropriate the English meaning of his name) but rather to the promise of the city itself. Symbolic of that record and of its nobler ambition, if you will, are the photographic panorama of San Francisco taken in 1855, the five panels of which are now in The Art Institute of Chicago (Figs. 2 and 4), and the oblong etching copied from it in France in 1856 at Pioche's command by the remarkable Parisian artist Charles Meryon. An impression of the latter is in the Graphic Arts Collection, Princeton University Library (Figs. 3 and 5).¹

¹ Our etching is No. 73, last state of 4, in the standard catalogue: Loÿs Delteil (with revisions by Harold J. L. Wright) *Catalogue Raisonné of The Etchings of Charles Meryon* (New York, 1924). Delteil's measurements should be 185 x 950 mm.

Thanks to Esther Sparks of The Art Institute for answering questions about the photographs and arranging for their publication. Also, to Gladys Hansen of the San Francisco Public Library for kindly pointing out Lloyd LaPage Rollins, "Charles Meryon and His 'Vue De San Francisco,'" *Quarterly of The Society of California Pioneers*, Vol. IX. No. 2 (June, 1932) 97-107. My efforts may be considered in part an expansion of his article. Thanks also to Elizabeth Roth of the Spencer Collection, New York Public Library, Alfred Bush of the Library here, and David Coffin and Peter Bunnell of the Department of Art and Archaeology for their helpful suggestions and bibliographic pointers.

Ironically, for reasons conceivably traceable in part to Meryon's own contribution to the rise of the aesthetic of "art for art's sake," and so to the neglect by most historians until recently of photography's relation to art, we are able to publish the photographs and the etching together here for the first time. But this, as our by now wiser experience of the modern age will realize, is just one from an imbroglio of ironies behind the commission. Not only did it involve the confrontation of an especially sensitive artist with photography, the one with his profound, not to say immemorial attachment to the poetic validity of manually drawn realism—the other with its irreversible destiny of technologically achieved, startlingly total realism, but also of two men, banker and artist, both deeply but very differently engaged in interpreting the urban ideals of their time or, to borrow a phrase from an 1855 issue of *Putnam's Weekly Magazine*, in interpreting "The great phenomenon of the Age . . . the building of great cities."²

"Of all the marvellous phases of the history of the present," wrote Bayard Taylor in 1849, "the growth of San Francisco is the one which will most tax the belief of the Future. . . . When I landed there, a little more than four months before, I found a scattering town of tents and canvas houses, with a show of frame buildings on one or two streets, and a population of six thousand. Now, on my last visit, I saw around me an actual metropolis, displaying street after street of well built edifices, filled with an active and enterprising people and exhibiting every mark of permanent commercial prosperity."³ Pioche apparently shared that prosperity and the vision of its permanence. Born to a wealthy family in St. Dizier, France, he had already established his double reputation as a daring investor and lover of the cultural refinements of urban life by running through his sizable legacy in Paris. Thereafter he had served briefly as *chancelier* in the French consulate in Chile, but when the news from California reached him, he had returned to finance. In fact, it was with a cargo of merchandise from Chile that he and his compatriot, the bookkeeper Jules B. Bayerque, arrived on February 20, 1849 to stake their claim among

² Vol. V (March, 1855). Cited here from Albert Fein, "The American City: The Ideal and Real," *The Rise of American Architecture*, New York (The Metropolitan Museum of Art [1970]), p. 52.

³ *The History of California* (New York, 1850), pp. 38-39.

the tents and canvas houses of San Francisco by opening an import and retail firm on Clay Street.⁴

How quickly the firm prospered can perhaps be glimpsed from remarks about it by one Ernest de Massey, whose journal and letters offer a detailed chronicle of a typically nearly disastrous experience in the Gold Rush. A few days after anchoring in the Bay in December, 1849, he describes Pioche's firm with the misgivings of one fresh from the masonry of civilization: "They run a large and flourishing business, make everyone welcome, and look after all business carefully, but I am not sure how substantial they are. Most of their capital is tied up in a building site located in the heart of the city with a wooden house on it." Three months later, chastened by life in San Francisco, he was ready to imply that the firm had at least some substantiality. Provisioned at last for the trek westward to the mines, he writes: "I am leaving for an indefinite period in which many things may happen [and did] and as I may never return alive from this wild and savage country I thought it best to give you some addresses . . . [to] get some trace of me." Among them he lists the firm of Pioche and Bayerque.⁵ In any case, by 1851 Pioche felt substantial enough and above all confident in the city enough to take the decisive step that made him San Francisco's chief banker for French capital. He sailed for Paris to enlist investors.

No doubt Pioche realized that fabulous tales of the Gold Rush and Napoleon III's consolidation of power combined to encourage speculation. Still, it was a creditable show of optimism. By European standards San Francisco was, after all, hardly more than a few wooden houses, many shipped "ready made" 'round the Horn, that seemed to suffer spectacular conflagrations with dismaying regularity. Further, government policy concentrated not on the city but on the mines, even to the extent of underwriting companies of laborers and soldiers, the *Guardes Mobiles*, to work

⁴ My information on Pioche is compiled from Daniel Lévy, *Les Français en Californie* (San Francisco, 1885), pp. 113 ff.; Lloyd LaPage Rollins, *op.cit.*, pp. 102-104; Robert O'Brien, *This is San Francisco* (San Carlos, Cal., 1948), pp. 268 ff.; Julia C. Altrocchi, *The Spectacular San Franciscans* (New York, 1949), pp. 163 ff., and Lawrence Kinnard, *History of The Greater San Francisco Bay Region*, I (New York, 1966) 458, *passim*.

⁵ "A Frenchman in the Gold Rush," translated by Marguerite Eyer Wilbur from the journal of Ernest de Massey, *California Historical Society Quarterly*, V, No. 1 (1926), 13, 42, *passim*.

French claims. But Pioche's optimism had to overcome, one imagines, the much greater obstacle of rampant gold fever. The propaganda of the Gold Rush made San Francisco more a gateway to romance than a reality in itself. The populace was showered with broadsides and manuals, complete with convenient maps, distributed by the numerous companies selling sea passages—*La Moisson d'Or*, *Le Nouveau Monde*, *L'Eldorado*, and the inevitable company that raffled tickets, the *Société de l'Ingot d'Or*—with tremendous success. By 1853 some thirty thousand Frenchmen had gone. Many had the backing for which Pioche himself was vying, but most went, as de Massey describes them, with “. . . no supplies, capital, credit, or friends of influence.”

Pioche, meanwhile, returned with six million francs. Initial investments were in lucrative rental properties, stores, wharves, and warehouses. Emphasis soon shifted, however, to the undeveloped hills rising above the harbor. This was to be Pioche's major contribution to the growth of San Francisco, and since it may well have had some bearing on the commissioning of Meryon, it seems important to reconstruct the chronology.

Pioche, Bayerque and Company purchased enormous tracts of real estate around Visitacion Valley, the Bernal and San Miguel Ranches, Mission Dolores, Hayes Valley, and the Western Addition during the period of land speculation that reached its peak in 1853. In 1853 Pioche again sailed for France and remained there until 1856. The news that reached him was alarming. The Gold Rush was over and the city was being abandoned by many empty-handed hundreds. By 1856 real estate values had plummeted. In the very months that the photographs were taken and the etching commissioned, then, Pioche was faced with huge investments in unmarketable land.

Pioche's solution was as confident and farsighted as his initial trip to France in 1851. He raised the necessary funds to open his land to development. On his return in 1856 he hired professional planners and two hundred French laborers to lay out Hayes Valley and the Western Addition. More boldly still, he built the first of San Francisco's great urban car lines, the Market Street Railroad, which ran by steam from Mission Dolores past Hayes Valley to the foot of Market. Thus he connected his developed real estate to the congested center of the city.

In later years Pioche extended the reach of the city by backing the San José Railroad, which joined to the Market Street line, and the Placerville and Sacramento, with its terminal at Folsom. He also backed the city's first gas works. Among his other interests were the Sierra Mining and Irrigation Flume, the Ely Mining District (*vide* the county seat of Pioche, Nevada), new kinds of hydraulic mining equipment and processes for treating ores, and, with an admirably Gallic twist, the bottling of New Almedan mineral water.

Pioche's enterprises, embracing banking, real estate, railroads and gas works made him a typically progressive mid-nineteenth century city builder. Yet it seems important to see his business undertakings within his whole way of life. For Pioche was one of San Francisco's first great collectors and patrons of the arts. He collected paintings, sculpture, bronzes, and porcelain. His houses, first on Mission Street and later on Stockton, were sumptuously furnished. He entertained lavishly. He is said to have had his artist-protégé Pietro Mezarra invent keepsake cameos and jewelry for his guests. He was a patron of the opera and a founding member of the Society of California Pioneers. And through it all he was an indefatigable *bon vivant*. At one time he is said to have imported forty chefs from Paris and a shipload of fine wines to enhance the city's French fare. Such extravagant gestures were perhaps the style, though a style not devoid of a certain utopian intoxication. He may even have gone too far, as he was accused of being generous to a fault to his court of hangers-on. In any case, there can be no doubt that Pioche sought to lead a cultivated life in the world's newest city. ". . . un homme qui joignant le goût des grandes entreprises à l'amour des beaux-arts et aux plus généreux sentiments du coeur," is how Daniel Lévy, who knew him, describes him. Indeed, it may be that the ultimate source of Pioche's faith in the city, beyond its promises of enterprise and culture, was a heart-felt wonder at its natural beauty. Perhaps the portrait most complete of him is neither at his banking house, nor among his collections, nor at the opera, but alone on the veranda of his private retreat, "The Hermitage," which he had constructed far up "at the feet," as he put it, of Mission Dolores. From there he could contemplate the majestic harmony of the city, the Bay, and the distant hills. As J. Wesley Jones lectured on the same

view, which he daguerreotyped in 1851, “. . . as from the loftiest seat in an amphitheatre, We look down upon the magnificent city of San Francisco . . .”⁶

In 1855 or early in 1856 Pioche, Bayerque and Company decided to commission a printed panoramic view of their beautiful city. The print, moreover, was to be copied from photographs or, technically speaking, from five daguerreotypes of which, in turn, five paper enlargements had been made. Who the daguerreotypist was we do not know. Nor do we know of any documents that clarify exactly the purpose of the project. Nor do we know how or why Charles Meryon, who had never before worked from photographs, was elected to carry the project out. We do know that Pioche was in France from 1854 until sometime in 1856, and the coincidence of his residence there with the commission would seem to clear up at least that mystery. Conceivably, having received the daguerreotypes from his partners in San Francisco or simply having come across them in Paris, Pioche himself handed them along with the enlargements and instructions to the artist.

From the photographs themselves we can deduce that the date—MDCCCLV—inscribed in the cartouche of the etching correctly gives the year the panorama was taken. The Gothic construction of Old St. Mary’s, visible in the fourth panel, was not completed until December, 1854.⁷ Also, Meryon’s own letters confirm the date—1856—inscribed in the etching’s lower left margin. From them we learn that he had obtained the commission by March, 1856, pulled the first proofs by September, and finally, a full year after beginning, finished the edition in March, 1857. His letters otherwise remain stubbornly vague about his patrons and any instructions they might have given him.⁸ But even if we know little more than these few facts, some speculation about the commission, involving as it did a banker, an artist, and photography at mid-nineteenth century, seems worthwhile.

Let us begin by pointing out that the concept of the commission

⁶ J. Wesley Jones, “Jones’ Pantoscope of California A Lecture . . .,” *California Historical Society Quarterly*, VI, Nos. 2 and 3 (June, Sept., 1927), pp. 109-129, 238-252. The quotation here: p. 251.

⁷ J. A. Baird, Jr., *Time’s Wondrous Changes. San Francisco Architecture* (San Francisco, 1962), pp. 15, 46 and plate 13.

⁸ Jean Ducros, Musée de la Marine, *Charles Meryon* (Paris, 1968). Exhibition catalogue. Letters published in Cat. No. 764. For Meryon’s other letters on the *San Francisco*, see Philippe Burty, *Gazette des Beaux-Arts* XIV (1863), 529-531.

was not novel. There were plenty of precedents for the reproduction of daguerreotypes in all the manually-prepared mass printing media of the time, wood-engravings, lithographs and steel intaglios. A lithograph of *Notre-Dame de Paris*, claimed to have been copied from a daguerreotype, was published in 1839, the very year Daguerre announced his process.⁹ Thereafter, architectural and topographical views were often copied—sometimes freehand and sometimes traced from photographic models. If, for example, Pioche read *Putnam's Monthly* in January, 1853, he was treated to “. . . a rapid glance, at the progress of New York and its architecture” in a pictorial essay of wood-engravings copied from daguerreotypes.¹⁰ Much closer to home was Francis Michelin's 1852 outsized color lithographic panorama “*City of San Francisco . . . from Daguerreotypes taken on the Spot.*” The spot was just down Nob Hill from that later occupied by Pioche's cameraman.¹¹ Still closer to the spot, indeed, just a few yards north of it, was the vantage for the 1854 daguerreotype panorama that appeared a year later as a lithographic plate in the *Annals of San Francisco* (Fig. 6). Naturally, it shows many of the same buildings that Pioche's shows, except Old St. Mary's. As for metal plate media, the frontispiece of the same book is a brilliantly steel-engraved copy from a daguerreotype of California Street taken by J. M. Ford (Fig. 7).¹²

Even so, the patron's wish to have the artist work from photographs is less self-evident than it would seem. In spite of the amazing advances in photography over two decades, most printed pictures by far in 1856 were still copied from sketches or water-

⁹ By L. Marquier in *Lithographie*, II (1839). Cited from Michael Twyman, *Lithography 1800-1850* (London: Oxford University Press, 1970), p. 252, Plate 158.

¹⁰ Vol. I, No. 2, p. 121. Cited from Richard Rudisill's excellent book *Mirror Image. The Influence of The Daguerreotype on American Society* (Albuquerque: University of New Mexico Press [1971]), p. 155. For a compact introduction to the subject: Beaumont Newhall, *The Daguerreotype in America* (Greenwich, Conn., 1968).

¹¹ *The Old Print Shop Portfolio*, XXXI, No. 4, p. 88. Numerous lithographic panoramas of early San Francisco are known, but which were based on sketches and which on daguerreotypes is not always clear. See Harry T. Peters, *California On Stone* (Garden City, New York, 1935) and Mel Scott, *The San Francisco Bay Area* (Berkeley, 1959), pp. 100 ff.

¹² Frank Soule, John H. Gihon, James Nesbit, Lewis Osborne, *The Annals of San Francisco* (New York, 1855). Reproduced here from the copy in the Rollins Collection of Western Americana in the Library. The lithograph is Peters, *op.cit.*, Cat. No. 37.

colors by artists “in the field.” The weight and bulk of photographic equipment, complications of exposure time and sunlight, problems with chemicals and preservation on one hand and, on the other, the halting development of satisfactory photo-mechanical reproduction provided part of the inertia. The rest—difficult for us to recollect—was habit-of-mind, the not only traditional pictorial habits but the ages-old association of pictures, including printed pictures, with the hand of an artist. Thus, the first and most fundamental question to ask Pioche is why photographs were preferred. The answer seems to lie in the special identification of photography with the Gold Rush.

One supposes that the decisive difference from other distant places and events that early photography recorded with such exhilaration, whether Niagara Falls, the Colossus of Rameses II, Perry’s expedition to Japan, or the great fire in Hamburg, was the fascination of gold. Furthermore, San Francisco was not only a distant place, situated literally on the edge of a wilderness, it was a city of astonishing growth. Far more dramatically than New York or Paris, it was a shining affirmation of civilization’s amazing progress. Distant place, fascinating event, international creation: San Francisco combined all the romantic, journalistic and ideological elements that made a photograph a photograph and not just a picture. It was no mythical Eldorado, lost in the mists of the mountains. It was exotically, indisputably real. Photographs proved it.

Indeed, we may be inclined to underestimate the extent of photographic propaganda engendered by the Gold Rush. New Yorkers, for example, thronged in 1851 to a sensational exhibition of 300 whole-plate daguerreotypes taken in 1850 by Robert H. Vance and entitled *Daguerreotype Panoramic View of California*. “On looking upon these pictures,” wrote one reviewer, “one can almost imagine himself among the hills and mines. . . .”¹³ Still more sensational was J. Wesley Jones’s *Pantoscope of California*, a dioramic newsreel of the overland rush from the Mississippi. Its painted scenes were copied from no less than 1500 daguerreotypes. To Jones’s stentorian commentary, from which we have already quoted vis-à-vis the view from Mission Dolores, the *Pantoscope*’s several hundred yards of canvas first unrolled to Boston audiences

¹³ In *The Photographic Art Journal*, II, No. 4 (October, 1851), 252 ff., cited from Rudisill, *op.cit.*, p. 140.

in 1852. With his mind on less material ore, Henry Ward Beecher reportedly said of seeing it, that one experienced “. . . the various stages of civilization, from the newest most recent town, up to the metropolitan grandeur of San Francisco.”¹⁴

San Francisco in the early fifties was perhaps the most daguerreotyped of all American cities, and for obvious topographical reasons, as well as ideological, the panorama was a favored form. Eight daguerreotype panoramas (or parts thereof) through 1855 have been located,¹⁵ which is an extremely high incidence of survival when, for instance, not one daguerreotype of New York City from before 1850 is known.¹⁶ The earliest of the eight dates from *circa* 1850 and was taken from the roof of the Union Hotel. From 1852 onward, the vantage moved progressively up Nob Hill.

And their truth remains. No matter how charming or intrinsically artistic the many sketches and water colors of Gold Rush San Francisco, they were and are not nearly such vivid documents as the daguerreotypes. There is no more memorable evocation of the Gold Rush than William Shew's 1852 panorama of the Bay from Rincon Point, in which appears in eerily minute and silent realism a veritable ghost fleet of anchored ships, their crews gone to the gold fields. In the catalogue to his exhibition, Vance took pains to stress photography's realism: "These views are no exaggerated and high-colored sketches, got up to produce effect, but are as every daguerreotype must be, the stereotyped impression of the real thing itself."¹⁷ As for panoramas of San Francisco specifically, here is one described in *Alta California* in 1851: "DAGUERREOTYPE OF SAN FRANCISCO.—Decidedly the finest thing in the fine arts pro-

¹⁴ On *Jones's Pantoscope* and others see John F. McDermott, "Gold Rush Movies," *California Historical Society Quarterly*, XXXIII, No. 1 (March, 1954), 29-38 and Rudisill, *op.cit.*, pp. 142-149 with Beecher quotation on p. 148.

¹⁵ Five are published by the San Francisco Maritime Museum, "Gold Rush Panoramas," *Sea Letter*, II, Nos. 2 and 3 (October, 1964) (Zelda Mackay Collection, Bancroft Library, University of California, 2 plate, *circa* 1850; George Eastman House, 5 plate, 1851; California Historical Society, 5 plate, 1851; Society of California Pioneers, 4 plate, 1851, with 5th plate in The Metropolitan Museum of Art, New York; Mr. Billy Pearson, 6 plate, 1853). One is published by Robert A. Weinstein, "San Francisco, The Golden City as the Argonauts Saw It," *California Historical Society Quarterly*, Vol. XLVII, No. 1 (March 1968), p. 72 (California Historical Society, 7 plate, 1851) one by Beaumont Newhall, *op.cit.*, plate 62 (Smithsonian Institution, 5 plate, 1852 by William Shew); The eighth is published here.

¹⁶ Rudisill, *op.cit.*, p. 155.

¹⁷ *Catalogue of Daguerreotype Panoramic Views in California* (New York, 1851), cited from Rudisill, *op.cit.*, p. 139.

duced in this city . . . is a consecutive series of Daguerrean plates, five in number, arranged side by side so as to give a view of our entire city. . . . It is intended for the 'World's Industrial Convention' in London. We venture the assertion that nothing there will create greater interest than this specimen of Art among us, exhibiting a perfect idea of the city which all the world carries with its name abroad more of romance and wonder than any other. It is a picture, too, which cannot be disputed—it carries with it evidence which God himself gives through the unerring light of the world's great luminary."¹⁸

In the light of such enthusiasm we can better understand the inspirational source of Pioche's commission. It represented not merely another instance of photography used as the model for a printed picture. It represented the use of a special *genre* of photography, especially identified with San Francisco, and especially signifiatory of photography's power. The point, obviously, is important. It enables us to assume that the essential and underlying aim of the commission was to transcribe the photographs accurately.

And yet, as we have just read in *Alta California*, photographic realism and fine art were not necessarily distinguished. At the same time we assume that accuracy of transcription was Pioche's essential instruction, we must also bear in mind that a work of art could well have been his expectation. Indeed, nowhere, and exactly in the mid-eighteen fifties, were photography, art, and realism more gloriously confounded than in Paris.¹⁹

To what degree the commission actually was motivated by pure aesthetics we cannot of course surmise. It would be nice to think that that was Pioche's primary motive, that, as a collector of art, he wanted the photographs transcribed by a recognized French artist, and that he chose Meryon because he had seen and admired the latter's extraordinary series of etchings depicting Paris. The fact is, however, that in 1855 and 1856 Meryon was hardly recognized. Ill, poor, emotionally disturbed by his illegitimate birth, and a recluse, he was hardly known. His artistic career had begun in earnest only six years earlier, when he made etching his sole *mé-*

¹⁸ San Francisco Maritime Museum, *op.cit.*, p. 1.

¹⁹ For an introduction to the relationship of art, photography, and realism in the mid-nineteenth century see Aaron Scharf, *Art and Photography* (Baltimore, 1969), a pioneering article, Beaumont Newhall, "The Daguerreotype and The Painter," *Magazine of Art*, XLII, No. 7 (November, 1949), 249 ff.

tier. In 1851-52 his entry in the Salon passed unnoticed; his entry in 1853, the impressive *Galerie Notre-Dame*, was refused. Entries in 1854 and 1855 passed again unnoticed. His great *Eaux-fortes sur Paris*, placed on sale in 1854 at Vignère's at only thirty francs the set, was a commercial failure. And he received no significant attention from the prolix French press until 1859.²⁰ Thus, if Pioche chose Meryon from purely aesthetic motives, he was exceedingly astute. Besides a more than casual familiarity with the Parisian art world, we would have to grant to him the same more than ordinary appreciative insight, if not the same romantic and republican sympathies as the few who eventually did recognize Meryon's genius, among them Victor Hugo, Charles Baudelaire, and Philippe Burty.²¹

On the other hand, it may well be that Pioche's motives were only indirectly concerned with art and that the commission went to the obscure Meryon more by happenstance—and certain assurances on the artist's part—than by aesthetics. Uppermost in Pioche's mind at the time may have been not art but business. As we have seen, 1855 and 1856 were years of financial crisis. With the cessation of the Gold Rush and consequent drop in land values, Pioche's chief, if not urgent, aim may have been to restore confidence and to stimulate further French investment in San Francisco by circulating, if you will, an accurate advertisement of its growth.

That the etching was commissioned with an extra-aesthetic purpose seems to find further and firmer support in the etching's grand cartouche, which serves to connect, tastefully but unmistakably, the city with the bankers. Flanked by the allegorical figures of Abundance and Industry, it carries the medallion portraits of Pioche and Bayerque and their initials. We might even go so far as to accept the cartouche as certain evidence of specific instructions, were it not for its strange history of artistic license. For ex-

²⁰ For a basic introduction to Meryon's life and work: Philippe Burty, "Charles Meryon," *Gazette des Beaux-Arts*, XIV (1863), 519-533 and XV (1863) 75-88; Loÿs Delteil, *op.cit.*; Jean Ducros, *op.cit.* Meryon's art did receive a short favorable review by Leon Goddard in 1855. See Burty, *op.cit.*, p. 521.

²¹ On the stature of Burty as art critic, see Gabriel P. Weisberg, "Philippe Burty, A Notable Critic of the Nineteenth Century," *Apollo* (April, 1970), pp. 297 ff. On the friendship of Meryon and Baudelaire see William A. Bradley, "Meryon and Baudelaire," *The Print Collectors' Quarterly*, I (1910), 587 ff. and Gustave Geffroy, *Charles Meryon* (Paris, 1926), pp. 125 ff.

ample, while the first trial proof of the etching shows the profile portraits of both Pioche and Bayerque, the second shows only that of Pioche. In the third and fourth, final proof, both portraits reappear.²² Still more strangely, in a letter written to Burty in 1861, Meryon claims that the cartouche was his idea, which he used to unite the composition and to hide the awkward convergence of perspective in the center foreground caused by photographing five contiguous views from the same position. “Je conçus également la pensée d’un titre mitoyen, d’essez grande dimension, qui pût masquer la partie centrale, en même temps qu’il servirait à relier . . .”²³ But in his journal of 1863, *Mes Observations*, the artist goes even farther. He claims that at one time he intended to avoid the difficulties of the foreground by introducing there a column of flames and smoke rising to the sky with birds of prey circling around the top of it. Well, however true to the city’s early history, we may take the liberty of imagining Pioche, hair standing on end, reacting to that idea, which surely tells us more about Meryon’s imagination than about the banker’s instructions or even the absence thereof.²⁴

The surviving preparatory drawings nonetheless indicate that Meryon did have some freedom in the cartouche’s invention. In one, for instance, an ornamentally linked sequence of palm tree, garland, and medallion motifs appears.²⁵ In another, the figure of Abundance holds a cornucopia rather than a wreath.²⁶ Another, which we reproduce here (Fig. 8), not only reveals a variation in the shape and decoration of the cartouche but also just one profile, that of Pioche. Still and all, the highly conventional design of the cartouche, finally resembling nothing more imaginative than a bank note, together with the portraits and initials, makes it difficult to believe that the patrons did not have at least some part in its invention, if nothing more than the request to somehow

²² Delteil, *loc.cit.*

²³ Burty, *op.cit.*, p. 530.

²⁴ Delteil, *op.cit.*, No. 73. (Translation from *Mes Observations* by Wright.) Meryon may have known one of the many prints of San Francisco aflame, e.g., Peters, *op.cit.*, plates 52 and 57. Plate 37 (our Figure 6) was twice issued, in 1854 and 1855, with conflagrations blocked in.

²⁵ E. Haverkamp-Begemann, *Drawings from The Clark Institute* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1964), Cat. No. 256. No. 257, also for the *San Francisco*, is studies of horses and riders.

²⁶ National Gallery of Art Rosenwald Collection, Alverthorpe, which houses an additional drawing for the figure of Industry. The Art Institute of Chicago houses also a drawing for Industry.

connect the city with their firm. The initials, after all, were not fantasy, and it seems safe to assume that neither were the portraits.

There is yet more evidence that the patrons may have mixed enterprise with art—the size of the edition. We have noted earlier that photographs were customarily reproduced in one of the mass printing media. Thus, nothing would be unusual about the fact that the *San Francisco* was etched in steel, except that Meryon normally used copper. In one of his letters to his father in 1856 about the commission, he states that he was etching for the first time in steel and for the explicit purpose of increasing the yield of impressions: “Ajoutez à cela que dans le but de pouvoir obtenir un grand nombre d’épreuves . . . j’avais entrepris pour la première fois de graver sur de l’acier.”²⁷ As with the cartouche, the idea here was surely not entirely his own.

If both accuracy of transcription and size of edition were indeed factors in the commission, and had the commission taken place a few years or even months later, and had the photographs themselves been better, that is, not requiring the hand of an artist to smooth over the awkward joining of one panel to the next, to unify the perspective, and to naturalistically redo the unnatural variations and contradictions in their lights and shadows, the patrons might well have turned to photo-mechanical reproduction.²⁸ Yet it is only fair to point out, that of the three manually prepared mass printing media commonly available, they chose the least popularizing. Employed mainly by publishers to reproduce works of art and to illustrate deluxe editions, steel intaglio was more closely identified with high art than either lithography or wood-engraving. Furthermore, most work in steel was engraved, not etched, and etching was at that very moment acquiring its mystique as an especially, not to say preciously artistic medium.

At this juncture of aesthetics and technology, however, our speculations require a closer look at the photographic panorama itself. Meryon’s letters, with frequent references to “petites placques daguerreotypées” and complaints of the acute ocular fatigue and dizziness suffered from trying to discern their details, leave the impression that he copied the *San Francisco* from the daguerreo-

²⁷ Ducros, *op.cit.*, Cat. No. 764.

²⁸ Certain photo-mechanical techniques, while already in use, were not yet commonly available. See Helmut Gernsheim, *The History of Photography*, revised edition (New York, 1968), pp. 539 ff.

types alone, an impression which the subsequent literature about the artist has tended to perpetuate. Thus, what one expects to find in The Art Institute of Chicago are the five daguerreotypes. What one actually finds, as several exhibitions and at least two authors ought to have sufficiently underscored, are the five photographic enlargements. The daguerreotypes, so far as we know, are lost.²⁹

How do we know, then, that the daguerreotypes ever existed, that the Chicago photographs were not themselves original, and that, it being the era of the daguerreotype, Meryon was not simply using the term generically? Aside from a single passage in Meryon's correspondence, which we shall explore momentarily, we can readily detect in the enlargements the telltale signs of the daguerreotypes: above all, the memory, as it were, of the daguerreotype's originally brilliant detail; additionally, the characteristic surface markings and the darkening around the borders, and, finally, the white, toneless sky and the almost total absence of animate life due to the necessary length of daguerrean exposure. That two blurred human figures do appear (in the right most panel) probably indicates that Pioche's daguerreotypes were smaller than the largest standard size, since the smaller the plate the shorter the period of exposure. Of course, we can not determine just which plate size actually was used, whether ninth plate, sixth plate, quarter plate, and so on, although we can say that the size of the individual enlargements (whose widths vary due to trimming) is greater than the largest standard plate. In that respect, the dimensions of the largest photographic panel in Chicago, 151 by 199 mm., also provide evidence of the lost daguerreotypes. Their proportions, 151: 151/199, correspond neatly enough to the thumb-rule for the standard proportions of American-cut daguerrean plates, that is, 1: 1.3.³⁰

²⁹ The enlargements go back to Meryon's friend Commandant de Salicis. They were subsequently exhibited in 1891: London, Christie, Manson, and Woods, *Catalogue of The Collection of Etchings by Charles Meryon of M. de Salicis*, Cat. No. 28; in New York in 1897; The Grolier Club. *A Catalogue of Etchings and Drawings by Charles Meryon*, 1898, Cat. No. 107; in 1909 they were purchased from Howard Mansfield and exhibited in 1911 by The Institute of Chicago, *Stickney Bequest, A Catalogue of Etchings and Drawings by Charles Meryon in The Howard Mansfield Collection*, Cat. No. 112 (a). Mansfield's introduction to the catalogue (p. 13) points out that they are photographs, not daguerreotypes. Rollins, *op.cit.*, p. 105 quotes in translation the passage we cite in note 31, below.

³⁰ The standard dimensions and proportions of American daguerrean plates are listed by Beaumont Newhall, *op.cit.*, p. 118.



Figure 1. Charles Meryon. *Le Stryge*. Etching. 1853
 Princeton University Art Museum. Gift of
 Mr. and Mrs. David H. McAlpin '20 in memory
 of Professor Clifton R. Hall.

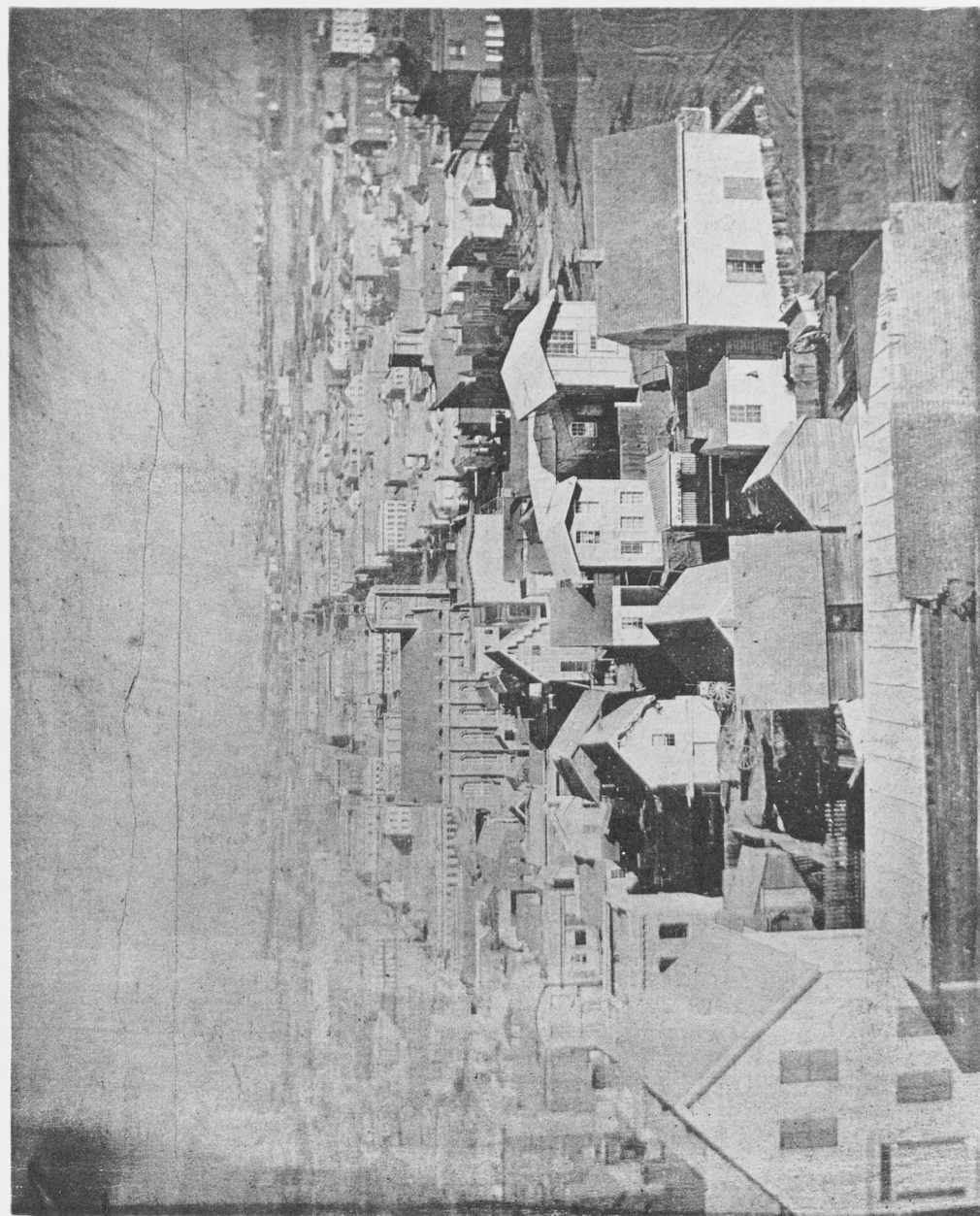


Figure 2. San Francisco in 1855. Detail of Figure 4.

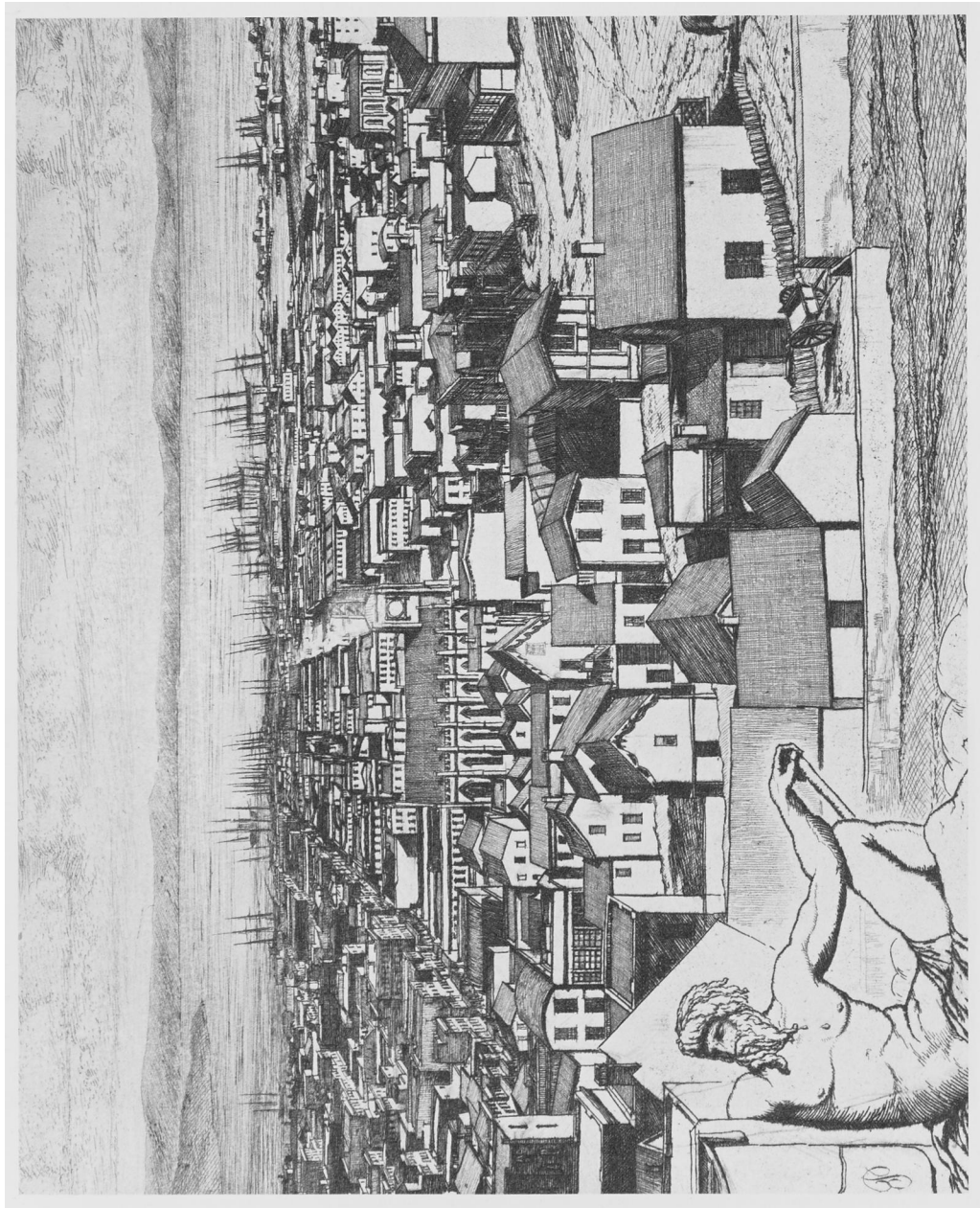


Figure 3. Charles Meryon. *San Francisco*. Etching. Detail of Figure 5.

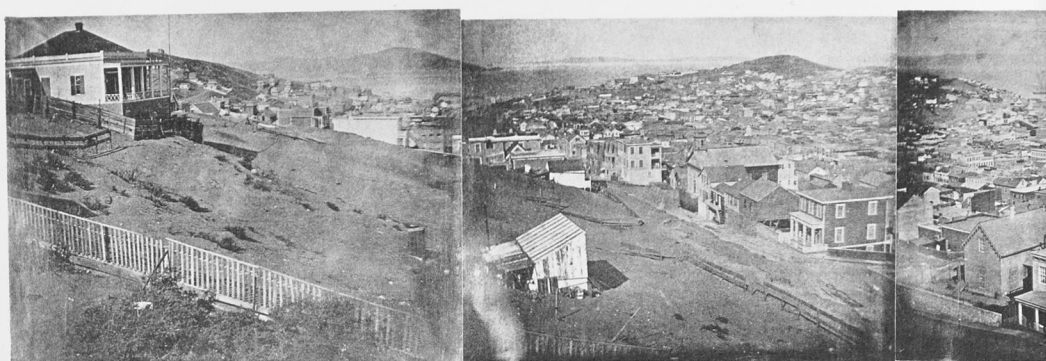


Figure 4. Paper enlargements of 5 plate daguerreotype
panorama of San Francisco. 1855.
The Art Institute of Chicago. Stickney Bequest.

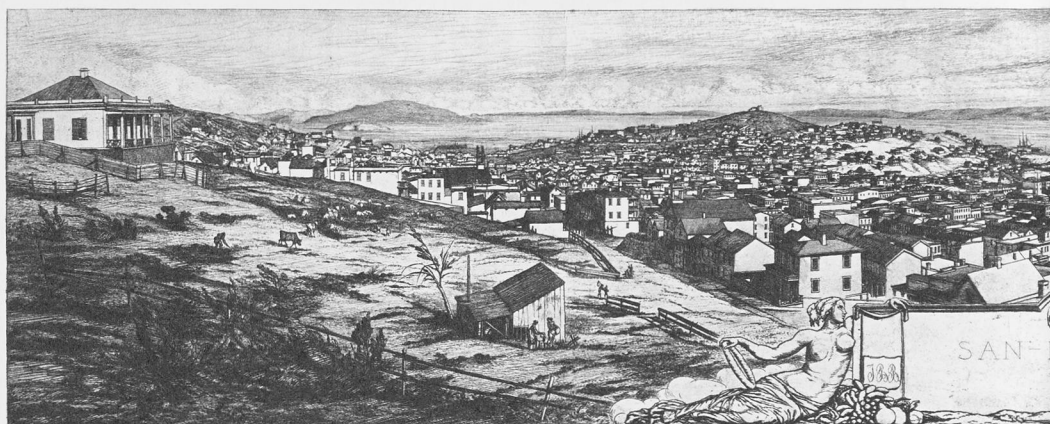
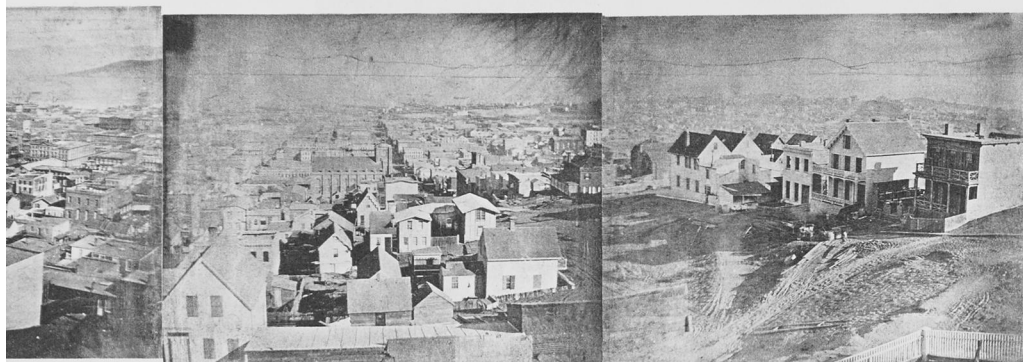


Figure 5. Charles Meryon. *San Francisco*. Etching and drypoint on steel. 1856.
Graphic Arts Collection, Princeton University Library.



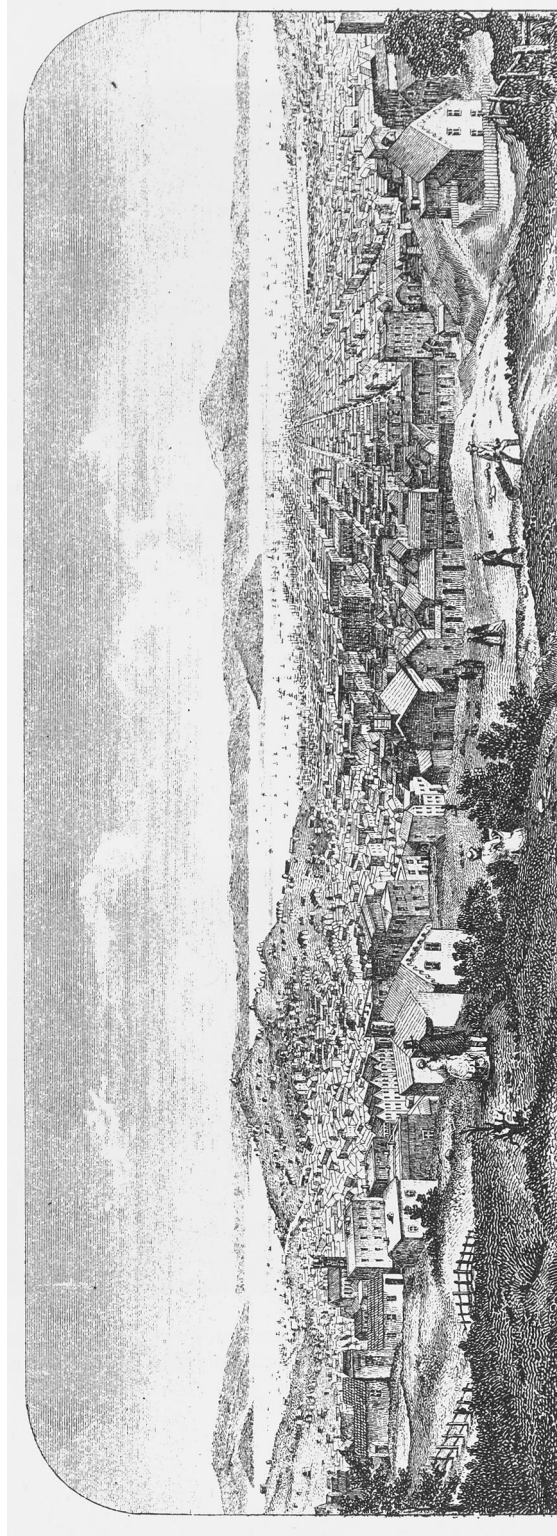


Figure 6. Lithograph after daguerreotype panorama from *Annals of San Francisco*, New York, 1855.
Philip Ashton Rollins Collection of Western Americana, Princeton University Library.

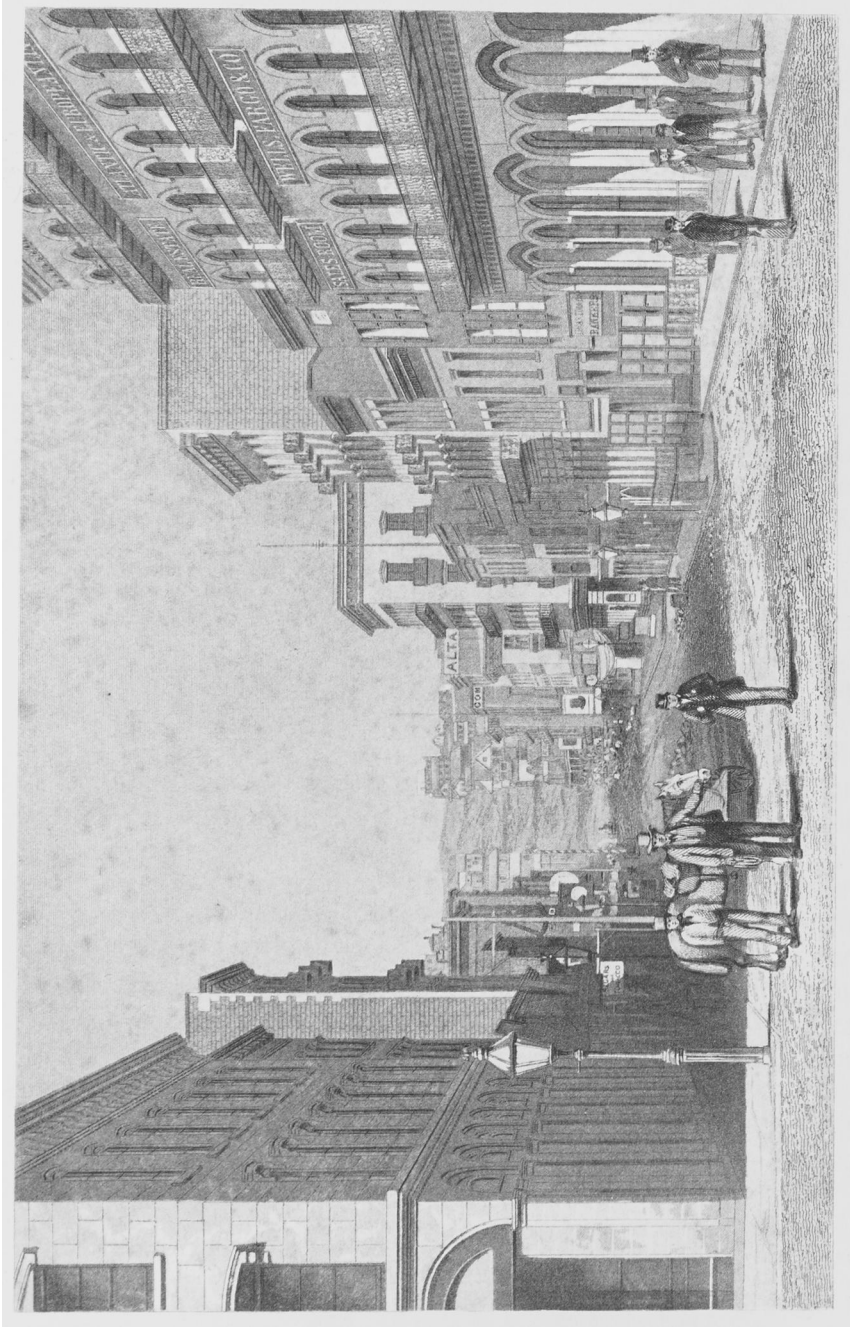


Figure 7. Steel engraving after daguerreotype of California Street by J. M. Ford. Frontispiece to *Annals of San Francisco*, New York, 1855.
Philip Ashton Rollins Collection of Western Americana, Princeton University Library.

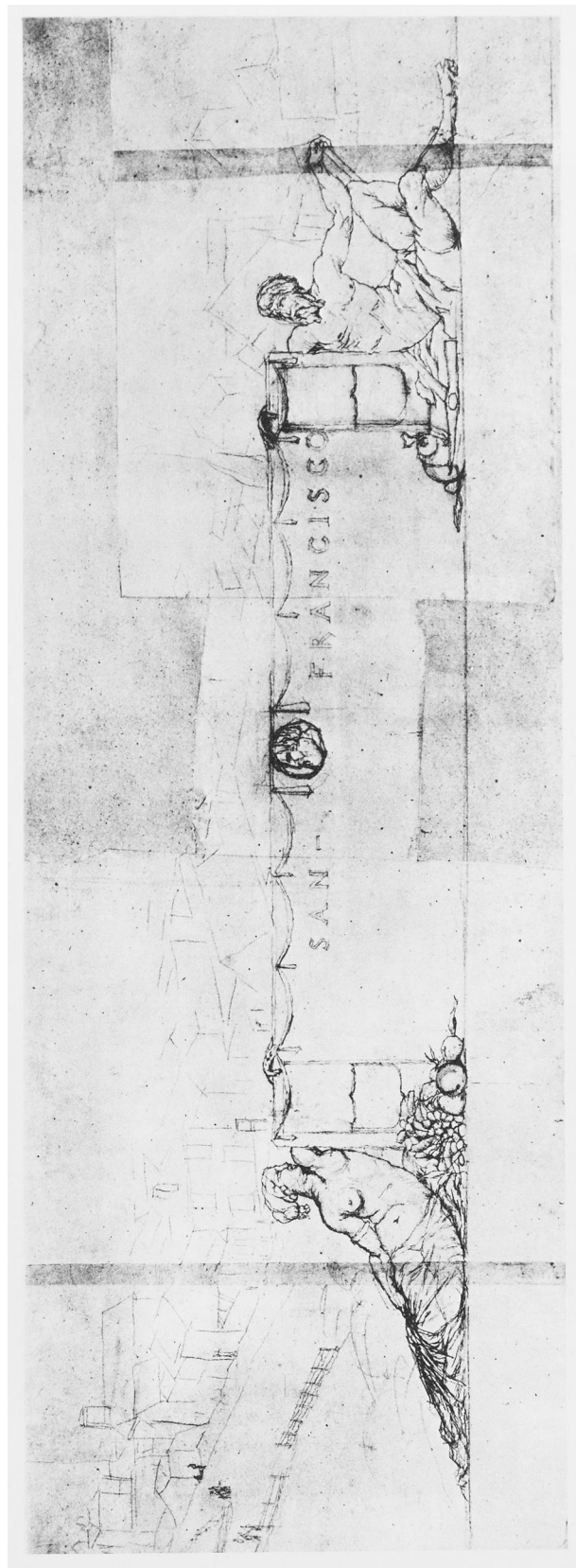


Figure 8. Charles Meryon. Study in pencil for his *San Francisco*.
Prints Division. The New York Public Library.
Astor, Lenox and Tilden Foundations.

How do we know, then, that the enlargements in Chicago were not made after 1856? For the answer to this, we must rely mainly on a passage in a letter which Meryon wrote to Burty about the *San Francisco*: “Les matériaux sur lesquels je devais opérer consistaient en un panorama Daguerre sur placques, composé de cinq petites vues carrées . . . Cependant, pour m’éviter cette fatigue que résulte du miroitement de la placque, on avait eu la complaisance de me livrer aussi chacune de ces vues partielles reportées sur papier.”³¹ Elsewhere, rather than “reportées sur papier,” he uses the phrase “l’épreuve daguerrienne” or “cinq épreuves juxtaposées de daguerréotype,” by which we now realize he meant exactly what an experienced printmaker would mean—impressions on paper.

Of course, more than one set of the enlargements may have been made. But the enlargements in Chicago are certainly the ones Meryon used. Not only does their provenance go back to the artist’s friend and protector, de Salicis, but they also bear what are surely Meryon’s own outlines in pencil of the hills beyond the Bay (Fig. 2).

Meryon, therefore, did have both the daguerreotypes and the enlargements. Unfortunately, his own explanation, that “on avait eu la complaisance” to deliver them to him to save him the fatigue that resulted from the glare of the daguerreotypes (caused by their glass protection against oxidation), is too politely indirect. We cannot surmise from it whether the enlargements were included at the initiation of the project or whether they were made later at his request. The very impersonality of his wording would suggest that his was the passive rôle.

Neither do we know how usual the enlargement of daguerreotypes as an aid to copyists was. Almost certainly painters like Charles Nègre in the early fifties used enlargements, perhaps projected directly onto their canvases, and it stands to reason that copyists in the graphic media used them, too. Yet, so far as we can determine, the Chicago panels used by Meryon are the only known documents of that procedure.³²

By far the most interesting technical aspect of the enlargements, however, is that they are on paper. More precisely, they seem to

³¹ Burty, *Gazette des Beaux-Arts*, XIV (1863), 529-30.

³² For the history of technology of photographic enlargements in this and the next two paragraphs my source is Helmut Gernsheim, *op.cit.*, pp. 311-17 and *passim*.

have been made from wet collodion negatives (glass plates) contact printed on paper with an albumen coating. This process, as opposed to the enlargement of daguerreotypes on larger daguerrean plates, which had been common practice since the forties among portrait photographers if not among graphic copyists, was most definitely advanced. It probably involved a device like the vertical enlarger with which Quinet had been experimenting in Paris since 1852 and Alphonse Liebert in the later fifties in Nevada and California, or else one like the "solar camera," a horizontal enlarger patented by David Woodward of Baltimore in 1857. In either case, the process had not yet moved in 1856 from the experimental to the patent stage, and the Chicago panels seem to be the earliest enlargements of their kind yet identified.

Whoever had the enlargements made thus had to go out of his way to do it. And the apparent reasons for doing it were to get beyond the usual daguerrean scale on one hand and to unite the five panels into a single view on the other. To enlarge the scale of daguerreotypes up to the scale of art, so to speak, had been a goal of photography from the beginning, a goal already achieved by 1856 by the soon-to-be predominant positive-negative processes. In this respect, Pioche's enlargements anticipate the mania for large photographic panoramas that developed around 1860, although the latter did not involve enlargements so much as the construction of large cameras. It is possible, in fact, that Pioche's enlarged panorama was not initially made as an aid to Meryon at all but as a work of art in itself. We will recall that Meryon spoke of "*cinq épreuves juxtaposées . . .*," so that he may well have received the enlargements already mounted together, as they are today, on cloth. Further, the variations in the widths of the enlargements—199, 188, 190, 196, and 185 mm.—must mean that they were trimmed in order to get rid of overlapping in the daguerreotype plates and in order to fit the paper panels snugly into a single, comprehensive and grand view.

The emphasis in Meryon's letters on the daguerreotypes no doubt expressed his recognition of both their technical and aesthetic priority. No doubt he was more fascinated by their silvery microscopic realism than by their comparatively dull paper enlargements. Yet it seems obvious that what Pioche really asked him to do was to copy the enlargements and that he did so with both scale and accuracy of transcription in mind. If the enlarge-

ments were initially made as a work of art, Pioche recognized its potential in a printed edition. If they were made specifically for the commission, then Pioche emerges as a patron memorable for his determination to get what he wanted.

The last question is the extent to which Meryon actually used the enlargements. Perhaps we need go no farther than to observe that the overall length of the panorama in Chicago is 950 mm., *including* around 3 mm. of space at the cloth joints of the panels, and that the etching is also 950 mm. in length. The height of the enlargements is 151 mm. and that of the etching 185 mm., but this difference of 34 mm. represents the sky added by Meryon. What is more, this conformity of outer dimensions between the etching and the Chicago enlargements applies with but occasional millimetric differences throughout. From apse to façade, Old St. Mary's in the etching and in the enlargement is the same size.

The conclusion to be drawn from the conformity of dimensions above is hardly avoidable. Meryon did use the enlargements, and far more substantially than his statement about evading the *miroitement* of the daguerreotypes would lead us to believe. In a word, he traced them.

How he traced them can be readily reconstructed from the surviving drawings, for all are on transparent India paper.³³ We are not surprised that their architectural and topographical elements conform in size to the same elements in the enlargements and the etching. They show how Meryon used the transparencies to adjust the perspective and unify the composition. With respect to the elements added by Meryon, particularly the cartouche, the drawing in the Spencer Collection is highly instructive. It indicates how the artist used the transparent paper to arrange the cartouche to cover just the area he wished. Since it is a pastiche of five separate pieces, it also tells us how he proceeded from one drawing to the next by scissoring out and reusing details that satisfied him. Finally, The Art Institute of Chicago houses a drawing of the first panel in reverse; it of course tells us how the tracings were transferred to the steel plate. In sum, Meryon used transparent papers just as many printmakers did to transfer their preparatory drawings. The only difference in this case was that the key preparatory drawing was the photographic panorama.

³³ Those listed earlier and two more in The Chicago Art Institute, a tracing of all five panels and of the first in reverse.

Such, then, was Pioche's side of the project—a marvellously un-sortable nineteenth-century mixture. Art, yes; but at the same time how better to demonstrate in a way that, let us say, “could almost not be disputed” how San Francisco had grown since he first appealed to French investors four years before. An etching, yes; but on steel. A remarkable artist, yes; but working from photographs. A work of art made by hand, yes; but based on enlargements made by the most advanced photographic technology.

And Pioche did get a work of art. If it was an advertisement, it was an extremely modest one. Certainly it was a far cry from the then proliferating *genre* of such urban advertisements, whose usually chromolithographic bird's-eye views of cities were surrounded and overlapped by typographic and sometimes by both typographic and pictorial directories to local churches, civic monuments, scenic sights, grand mansions, notable railway bridges, principal industries, substantial banks and busy emporia. Nor, apparently, did Pioche require “Copied from Daguerreotypes, taken on the spot.”

Indeed, the etching has a dignity that transcends all our speculations. It does not ultimately allow us to overlook the possibility that Pioche meant above all to praise not just San Francisco but the idea of San Francisco, the ideal of the city, which had been revealed to him through the photographic panorama itself. It may even be that he discovered in the panorama some of that expansive self-confidence characteristic of American thought about cities in those days, of cities building in and with the grandeur of the land, free from the past, in “. . . the country of the Future . . . of beginnings, of projects, of designs, of expectations.”³⁴

The imaginative, reclusive, and mentally unstable Meryon was, at least on one level, the right artist for Pioche's commission. He had an obsessive appetite for architectural forms. His *Eaux-fortes sur Paris*, among them the *Galerie Notre-Dame* with its warren of Gothic details and *La Pompe Notre-Dame* with its forest of scaffolding, reveal an incredible bending of the will to observation. The pencil drawings from which the etchings were made testify even more eloquently to his visual concentration as well as to his

³⁴ Ralph Waldo Emerson, “The Young American” (lecture delivered in Boston in 1844) in *Miscellanies* (Boston, 1860), p. 359 and *passim*. The pioneering historical introduction to thought on cities in ante-bellum America is Lewis Mumford, *The Golden Day* (New York, 1927). For the iconography of urban views, see John W. Reps, *The Making of Urban America* (Princeton University Press, 1965).

daily, almost tactile and psychic cohabitation with the buildings, streets, and stones of old Paris.³⁵

At every other level, however, the commission and the artist would seem to have been utterly mismatched. Meryon looked upon his city with a kind of Gothic mysticism. To him, buildings were anything but symbols of mankind's capacity for progress. They were rather expressions of ancient and mysterious passions, accretions of time and evil. Hardly panoramic, his perspectives were close, moody and unexpected. His belief in artistic license led him to combine two views into one or to alter the locations of buildings or the buildings themselves.³⁶ Of lights and shadows he made disconcerting patterns. His skylines were definitely not untroubled. They were haunted by Gothic towers and circling birds of prey. The grotesque in his etching *Le Stryge* he conceived as watching over Paris: "Insatiable Vampire l'éternelle Luxure . . ." (Fig. 1).³⁷

Meryon saw Gothic buildings both visually and conceptually, not to say symbolically, and such was his conceptual need that he often verbalized his architectural imagery. He wrote poems which he sometimes etched and ornamented as separate prints and sometimes inscribed within his architectural etchings. We find across the top of *La Rue de Mauvais Garçons*, for example: "Quel mortel habitat/ En ce gîte si sombre?/ Que donc là se cachait/ Dans la nuit et dans l'ombre? . . ."³⁸

Meryon's then was an intensely imaginative yet ambivalent identification with a city of the past, the unique creation of centuries that made up the crowded, notoriously dirty, decayed, and crepuscular streets and habitations of medieval Paris. And it was this Paris, source of disease and republicanism, that Napoleon III and his "urbaniste-demolisseur" Baron Haussmann were in the process of levelling. "Thanks to the fruitful plan of the Emperor," went the official line, "architecture transforms our cities . . ."³⁹

³⁵ For an introductory survey: William A. Bradley, the "Drawings of Charles Meryon," *The Print Collector's Quarterly*, VII (1921), 223 ff.

³⁶ Phillip Cate, *Meryon's Paris/Piranesi's Rome*, University Art Gallery, Rutgers University, 1971. This exhibition demonstrated the extent of such alterations by pairing the views in Meryon's etchings with modern photographs of the same views.

³⁷ Delteil, Cat. No. 23.

³⁸ *Ibid.*, Cat. No. 27.

³⁹ Achille Fould in *Le Moniteur Universel* (1857), cited from Linda Nochlin, *Realism and Tradition in Art 1848-1900* (Englewood-Cliffs, New Jersey, 1966), p. 4.

The imagination of Meryon and his austere and macabre morality, much as they portrayed old Paris as the capital of vice, were hardly attuned to so grand a plan of urban renewal. He was not the artist to be forced into the open and onto the spacious boulevards that were sweeping through the city with panoramic impersonality. He was bitterly aware that many of the buildings he lived with, drew and etched were scheduled for destruction, as was the house that inspired *La Rue de Mauvais Garçons* shortly after he made the print. The poems he addressed to these condemned buildings are whimsically ironic and sad. To the ancient pumping station adjacent to Notre-Dame: "C'en est fait,/ O forfait! / Pauvre Pompe,/ Sans pompe,/ Il faut mourir; . . ." ⁴⁰ For his etching of the *Ancienne Porte du Palais de Justice*: "La cas vraiment est grave/ Et tristement je grave/ Que pour l'exorciser/ Il faudrait la . . . raser . . ." ⁴¹

Not surprisingly, Meryon's art became in the later fifties a rallying point for the opponents of Haussmann and the Empire. Then as now much literary exercise was made against the deaf colossus of modernizing change, and the *Eaux-fortes sur Paris* were inevitably allied with the Empire's most prestigious enemy, Victor Hugo. The great author knew the etchings. In 1859 he wrote to Baudelaire in response to the latter's inspired page on Meryon in *La Revue Française*: "Puisque vous connaissez M. Meryon, dites-lui que ses splendides eaux-fortes m'ont ébloui . . . Ses planches vivent, rayonnent et pensent." ⁴² Two years later Hugo also wrote to the critic Philippe Burty about Meryon: "Fortifiez-le par tous les encouragements possibles," he again urged. "Le souffle de l'immensité traverse l'oeuvre de M. Meryon et fait de ses eaux-fortes plus que des tableaux—des visions . . ." ⁴³

But it was Burty himself in the *Gazette des Beaux-Arts* in 1863 who most explicitly opposed Haussmann's unfeeling demolitions of the city's antiquity with Meryon's art: ". . . Il a exprimé avec une clarté toute française la poésie intime et suprême de ce vieux Paris qu'il réserve à notre génération de demolir et défigurer sans pitié." Again: "Mais la Ville, *Alma mater*, ne devait-elle pas au moins conserver aux générations suivantes le souvenir de ce qui allait disparaître sous la pioche des démolisseurs? La photographie suffit-elle pour écrire l'histoire du passé? . . . A-t-on donc songé à

⁴⁰ Delteil, *op.cit.*, Cat. no. 32.

⁴¹ *Ibid.*, Cat. No. 20.

⁴² Ducros, *op.cit.*, Cat. No. 449.

⁴³ *Ibid.*, Cat. No. 455.

faire prendre à M. Meryon des croquis qu'il pût graver tour à tour, et que l'on aurait appelés *l'Album historique de la ville de Paris*?"⁴⁴

Burty's disdainful dismissal of photography as being unable to penetrate and preserve the soul of old Paris, as Meryon's etching did, brings us to the final ironies behind the commission. For to Burty, as to Baudelaire, Alfred Cadart, Théophile Gautier and other intellectuals of the day, there had taken place around 1855 a revival of the art of etching by Meryon, Seymour Haden, Jongkind, Millet, Bracquemond, Whistler and others which was revealing the new way of art in opposition to photography. To Baudelaire, it was the very restoration of creative imagination itself—that "Reine des Facultés"—which made art, art, and which was the implacable, irreconcilable, aristocratic opponent of photography and its unimaginative realism and vulgarly popular appeal. So it happened, in fact, that the first important notice of Meryon's art, by Baudelaire, appeared among the same editorial letters by which the critic, in his reaction to the inclusion of photographs with the fine arts in the Salon of 1859, delivered the century's most vitriolic and effective attack on photography and its public.⁴⁵

Amusing though it would be to quote from Baudelaire's famously scathing letters here, his essential arguments against the camera and for the art of imagination were succinctly summed up three years later by Gautier in his introduction to the initial album of original etchings published by the revivalists, who had become formally organized as the *Société des Aqua-Fortistes*: "En ce temps où la Photographie charme le vulgaire par la fidélité mécanique des ses reproductions, il devait se déclarer dans l'art une tendance au libre caprice et à la fantaisie pittoresque. Le besoin de réagir contre le positivisme de l'instrument-miroir a fait prendre à plus d'un pientre la pointe sur graveur à l'eau-forte, et de la reunion de ces talents, ennuyés de voir les murs tapissés de monotones images d'où l'âme est absente, est née la *Société des Aqua-Fortistes* . . ." ⁴⁶

Ah, Baudelaire. In the same year he, too, wrote at length of the

⁴⁴ XIV, p. 523, XV, p. 76. Burty was perhaps deriding the photographic efforts of the Société Héliographique and its Comité des Monuments Historiques.

⁴⁵ Charles Baudelaire, *Oeuvres Complètes*, III (Paris, 1966), 423 ff. First published in *Revue Française* (June-July), 1859.

⁴⁶ Société des Aqua-Fortistes, *Eaux-Fortes Modernes*, I (Paris: Cadart et Luquet, 1862-3).

etching revival in *Le Boulevard*, and in that article he again praised Meryon and pointed, yes, to none other than the *San Francisco* as Meryon's masterpiece. "Nous avons vu aussi chez le même éditeur [Cadart] le fameuse perspective de San-Francisco, que M. Meryon peut, à bon droit, appeler son dessin de maîtrise. M. Niel, propriétaire de la planche, ferait vraiment acte de charité en faisant tirer de temps en temps quelques épreuves. Le placement en est sûr."⁴⁷

Certain passages in Meryon's own correspondence suggest that he shared, though perhaps with less vehemence, the artistic resentment of photography. Writing to his father in 1853 of *La Rue des Toiles à Bourges* he says: "La composition de cette pièce m'a coûté beaucoup plus de peine qu'on ne saurait le croire: comme je ne me suis jamais aidé jusqu'ici de Daguerreotype (cela pour plusieurs raisons) . . ."⁴⁸ Unfortunately, we never learn what his reasons were. Elsewhere, concerning his etching of *La Pompe Notre-Dame*, he intimates that the uniqueness of his eye for picturesque subject matter was in competition with the facile ubiquity of cameras: "Je ne la verrai détruire qu'avec peine (quoique sa disparition ne puisse nuire à la valeur de ma gravure) car c'est au milieu de Paris une pièce rare et curieuse. Si le Daguerreotype n'était quand même pas là pour recevoir les images des choses, je serais peut-être le seul à avoir gravé ce sujet."⁴⁹

Small wonder, then, that Meryon, as he labored over the *San Francisco*, found the commission, with its alien photographs, so perfectly like reality yet so tactily abstract, and its strange city, so distantly seen and devoid of the past, torturous. Among his correspondence concerning the project are some anguished letters written to his father during the year he worked on it. We shall quote only two or three portions here. March, 1856: "Mon ouvrage sur Paris est, comme je vous l'ai dit, terminé; pour le moment je suis chargé d'un travail assez important qui va me donner de l'occupation pendant cinq or six mois: c'est une planche d'assez belle dimension représentant le panorama de San Francisco. Le sujet est à la vérité assez peu pittoresque . . ." September: "Il me faut un courage excessif pour toujours aller. Je viens d'obtenir de premières épreuves d'une grande planche à laquelle j'ai travaillé

⁴⁷ "Peintres et Aqua-Fortistes," *op.cit.*, p. 514.

⁴⁸ Ducros, Cat. No. 744.

⁴⁹ Also to his father, 1853. Ducros, Cat. No. 644.

pendant tout le beau temps. Je vous en ai déjà parlé: c'est une grande vue de San Francisco, dont le dessin m'avait été donné en cinq épreuves juxtaposées de daguerréotype. Comme ces épreuves ne se raccordaient que difficilement tant à cause de la déviations des lignes que de la confusion qui existe toujours aux limites, il m'a fallu une peine inouïe pour en faire un seul dessin à peu près correct. L'innombrable quantité de maisons, d'édifices divers, l'extrême finesse de certains détails me faisaient concevoir, pendant toute la durée de l'exécution, des craintes bien sérieuses relativement à la réussite de mon oeuvre." Finally, March, 1857: "J'ai terminé ma vue de San Francisco à mon grand soulagement: je sais seul la peine que cette pièce m'a donnée."⁵⁰

The amazing thing is that he did finish it. He spent an entire year, as it were, near the intersection of California and Powell Streets. Nor, presumably, could he name what he was tracing, whether Old St. Mary's, City Hall, the Montgomery Block, the Telegraph Station, or even Telegraph Hill. Likewise, the rather unfamiliar architecture, the Quebec and Monterey style houses, the pipe-stem colonnettes, lancet windows, and barge boards must have caused him more than once to doubt his vision.

Nonetheless, the etching is infused with Meryon's poetry. The glowing contrast of light and shadow, the heightened sky, the little figures and grazing animals, and the effectively simple cartouche, wafted on ethers, make it, overall, a surreal San Francisco, a mysteriously quiet symbolist city. Could it be, that despite the ironies of the undertaking, Meryon sensed, as did Pioche, the photographic panorama's symbolic transcendence?

Perhaps, after all, the cartouche really was Meryon's idea, which he invented less for his stated reasons than for its power to secure the panorama to a symbolic plane. Self-contained yet quietly uniting the whole panorama, the cartouche seems to tell us that as much as we are viewing a particular city we are viewing in the panorama a form used by artists to signify the city as ancient as art itself.

Further, could it be that the *San Francisco* commission somehow freed Meryon from his dark passage through old Paris? Is it possible that he saw it, if not exactly as Pioche's vision of beauty, abundance, and industry, as a dreamed-of place of serenity and health? How, in fact, are we to explain the additions that Meryon made?

⁵⁰ Ducros, Cat. No. 764.

What of the sky, massed over the panorama as a great volume of clouds and air?⁵¹ And what of the figures, the shepherd, the gardener, the laundresses, the little travellers in the uncrowded and sunny streets? And the grazing cattle and sheep? Could they have been Pioche's idea? Taking all the additions together, Meryon seems to have had his own ideal of progress, a kind of new harmony or peaceable kingdom.

If we look among the artist's poetry we do find a curious piece, etched in 1855, which we may well wish to apply to his vision of San Francisco. It is entitled the *Loi Solaire*: "If I were Emperor or King of some powerful State, (which I would not wish, nor be able, to be)—Considering that large cities are engendered solely by sloth, avarice, fear, lust and other bad passions; I would cause to be elaborated a law determining, in as precise a manner as possible, the area of ground, with or without cultivation, to be compulsorily adjoined to each habitation of desired capacity for a given number of human beings so that air and sunlight, those two elements essential to life, may ever be widely distributed. This law: source of all material, and consequently moral, well being will be called: Solar Law."⁵²

Whatever Meryon's interpretation, the *San Francisco* did not bring him fame and fortune, as Baudelaire was so sure it would. Whether it satisfied Pioche, or served his purpose, we do not know.

Meryon's aesthetic sensibilities apparently never recovered from his encounter with the new technology. Some months after he finished working over the photographs his mental instability became so severe that he had to be removed to Charenton. Following his release in 1859 under the protection of de Salicis, he never again was able to sustain the effort that produced his first installments of the *Eaux-fortes sur Paris*, and some have judged that the prints he made after the *San Francisco* are too topographical. In 1866 he

⁵¹ Meryon did the sky in drypoint.

⁵² Delteil, Cat. No. 93. Translated by Adele M. Holcomb in her excellent article "Le Stryge de Notre-Dame: Some Aspects of Meryon's Symbolism," *College Art Journal*, XXXI, No. 2 (1971-2), 156 and *passim*.

was removed once more to Charenton and there he died of self-starvation in 1868.

Meanwhile, Pioche's fortunes were similarly sad. In 1862 an ecological disaster in the form of a flash flood of mud and water from Sans Souci Lake in the hills above his home on Mission Street ruined his house and property, which thereafter became known as Pioche's Pond. Ten years later, for reasons apparently related to over-confident investments and to the banking failures of 1870, he too committed suicide. He left no children to see the Burnham plan in 1906 for redoing San Francisco in the style of Haussmann. Nor did anyone see it done, since the plan was approved by the City Council on the eve of the Great Earthquake. Still, if you take your aesthetic sensibilities up California Street today to the spot where Pioche's daguerreotypist once stood, you can scarcely see the Bay, or the city, for the buildings.